

Metaphysics: The Truths of the Universe

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Philosophy is the love (philo) of wisdom (sophia), but what is wisdom and why do we value it? This question is at the start of Aristotle's famously written book, *Metaphysics*. Aristotle argues that wisdom is knowledge of the first causes. Knowledge of the first causes is knowledge of the most fundamental and general things because it unveils the why a thing is so. Knowing the why a thing is so is valuable because it verifies that we can know, and humans long to know. While Aristotle's explanation of wisdom is a satisfactory and sufficient one, it is not necessary for wisdom.

First, wisdom is knowledge of the fundamental causes and principles. For instance, in *Alpha*, Aristotle writes that "It is clear, then, that wisdom is knowing having to do with certain principles and causes" (6). In other words, wisdom is not just about knowing anything, it is about knowing certain things, which is certain causes and principles. Aristotle explains these "certain causes and principles" as the fundamental causes of the universe.

If we are to have knowledge about the causes and principles, we must first recognize how we know things in general. First, we can know things from our senses, which is also known as a posteriori knowledge. This is knowledge by observation or experience. To illustrate, imagine a chocolate chip muffin is on the table next to you. You can know that it is in fact on the table by observing it with your senses of sight, smell, and touch. Much of science is done using a posteriori knowledge because it is done through observation with the senses. Hence, one way of knowing is a posteriori knowledge.

We can also know things from thought, which is a priori knowledge. A priori knowledge is knowledge prior to experience. For instance, prior to seeing it, you can know that a chocolate muffin contains cocoa because chocolate is made from cocoa, and it is a chocolate muffin. In the first example, knowledge of the muffin comes from experience and in the second example knowledge of the muffin comes from thought. Therefore, we can either know things a priori or posteriori.

This is an important distinction for Aristotle because knowledge a priori is knowledge of the universals, which is what the skilled know, and knowledge a posteriori is knowledge of the particulars, which is what the experienced know. Aristotle believes this is the case because “the skilled know the cause, whereas the experienced do not. For the experienced know the ‘that’ but not the ‘because’, whereas the skilled have a grasp of the ‘because’, the cause.” (4). Here, the skilled are people like doctors who understand the theoretical cause for a symptom like the flu, whereas the experienced do not, they only know the experience of being sick. Therefore, a priori knowledge is universal because it is knowledge of the theory for why a thing is so, and a posteriori knowledge is knowledge of the particular because it is knowledge of an instance or experience of a thing.

Furthermore, Aristotle associated the causes with universality, but what are the causes? The causes are explanations of change that can be classified into four questions in order to answer the question *why*? Aristotle argues that there are four causes, “and the causes are spoken of in four ways, of which one cause we say to be the substance and the essence . . . the

second is the matter and substrate, and the third is that from which comes the beginning of the change, and the fourth is the opposite cause to this, the ‘wherefore’ and the good” (3). In other words, the four causes are the material cause, the formal cause, the efficient cause, and the final cause. For Aristotle, wisdom is knowledge of a thing by knowing the why or cause for it and collectively each of these four causes can explain and answer that.

The first cause is the material cause, and it is the innate material a thing is made of, in other words, its *thisness*. For instance, Aristotle describes the material cause as “An intrinsic feature from which something is produced. Examples: the bronze is the cause of the statue, the silver of the salver.” (115). Aristotle’s example clearly illustrates how the statue’s material cause is the bronze or *thisness* from which it is made. The concept of a material cause can universally apply to anything because it examines what makes a thing a thing by investigating what it is made from.

The second cause is the formal cause, and it is change of a material thing into a new thing by design. For example, Aristotle explained the formal cause as “The form and template, which is the account of the what-it-was-to-be-that-thing.” (115). Aristotle’s definition describes the cause of a substance changing forms or shape. If we apply this explanation to the example of a table, then we can see that the material cause is the wood and the formal cause is the design of the wood into a table. The formal cause of a thing is the explanation of the change in substance from one form to another. Hence, the formal cause conceptually is also universal because it can be asked about anything since it is investigating

why a thing is shaped or comes in the way that it does.

Third, the efficient cause is the knowledge of the agent who changed the substance from its material cause form to its formal cause form. To illustrate, Aristotle details the efficient cause as “The source of the primary principle of change or stasis. For example, the man who deliberates is the cause of action, and the father is the cause of the child. In general, the producer is the cause of the product and the changer of the thing changing.” (115). Aristotle is defining the efficient cause as the changer which makes a thing change. Again, we can apply this to a table by showing the efficient cause is the carpenter who put the wood together to make the table. Clearly, the efficient cause is universal because it can ask of anything, how did the change of a thing change and why.

The efficient cause leads us directly to the fourth cause, which is the final cause. The final cause is the end purpose or goal for a thing. For instance, Aristotle claimed the final cause was the “Cause as end. The end of something is what that thing is for.” (115). When we arrive at the fourth cause, we understand in full what is the thing and why it is here. In our previous table example, our final cause was to sit at the table. Therefore, Aristotle’s final cause can universally ask why are you here to a thing?

Aristotle’s four causes examine in an abstract way, what a thing is. He breaks down what a thing is using these four causes as a method for understanding. This method of understanding can be applied to anything like the thing next to you. For instance, if I pick

up a glass of water, I can say, this is made of glass shaped into a cup by a designer so I can drink from it. Now, I can definitively say why this cup is and why it is here. Therefore, Aristotle's four causes tell us why a thing is.

Aristotle's definition of wisdom also includes knowing certain principles. Aristotle explains the essence of principles as "The common feature, then, of all principles/starts is to be the primary origin (of being, production or cognition)." (114). In other words, he is claiming that a principle is the genesis of a thing. To illustrate, a principle of a table is the seed from which a tree grew and made the wood that made the table.

Aristotle makes the claim that the principles and causes are the same. For example, he writes, "And for each account of principle/start there is an account of cause, unsurprisingly in that all causes are principles" (114). This reveals that Aristotle takes wisdom to be the investigation abstractly of the first principles and causes of the universe because every material thing can be investigated back to its origin, which is nature. From this we can then ask, what created nature. This will lead us to investigate the origin of the origin. For Aristotle, this is the prime mover, for others it may be the big bang. Either way, Aristotle is saying wisdom is the investigation of the origin's origin.

While Aristotle's explanation of how the causes and principles lead to wisdom are in depth and well-argued, it is unnecessary. It is unnecessary because there are other types of wisdom like that of Socrates', which is not over complicated. For instance, the wisdom of

Socrates was can be summarized with one phrase: the only thing I know is that I know nothing (Cohen 93). Socrates was the wisest man in Athens because he did not claim to know things he didn't. Instead he investigated them because he knew he did not know them whereas Aristotle's position claims that you have to know about the causes and principles first in order to be lead to know about the origin.

Here, we can apply Occam's Razor to show that the argument with the fewest assumptions is the best explanation. Socrates' definition of wisdom had fewer assumptions than Aristotle's because it only assumes one thing, that we know nothing. Whereas Aristotle's definition of wisdom assumes knowledge of the first causes and first principles, which leads to a hole of more assumptions. If both philosopher's types of wisdom are true, then why not choose the simple and clearer one?

In conclusion, Aristotle thoroughly explains wisdom as having knowledge about the origin of the origin, and why it is valuable, but it was unnecessary. It was unnecessary because through the causes, he is led to asking the question: what are the truths of the universe? He does so to find out about the origin's origin. Socrates, in contrast, simply had to accept the wisdom that he knew nothing, as he would thereby be prompted to seek the truths of the universe.

Works Cited

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